

IN CONTEXT

GENRE

Horror

DIRECTOR

Robert Wiene

WRITERS

Hans Janowitz, Carl Mayer

STARS

Werner Krauss, Conrad Veidt, Friedrich Fehér, Hans Heinrich von Twardowski, Lil Dagover

BEFORE

1913 *The Weapons of Youth* is Wiene's first movie, now lost.

AFTER

1924 *The Hands of Orlac*, an Expressionist movie by Wiene, is later remade twice and inspires many horror movies.**1925** Wiene directs a silent movie of Richard Strauss's opera *Der Rosenkavalier*. Strauss conducts a live orchestra for the premiere, but a tour of the US is canceled with the arrival of sound movie.

“

I have never been able since to trust the authoritative power of an inhuman state gone mad.

Hans Janowitz

”



The *Cabinet of Dr. Caligari* has been described as the first feature-length horror movie, and it is easy to see its legacy in modern cinema, but not for the obvious reasons. Its ingenious set design—still avant-garde in its use of palpably unreal, theatrical environments—is the most striking of its features. Yet it is other, more subtle elements of Robert Wiene's groundbreaking psychological thriller that have become fixtures of movie storytelling.

The “unreliable narrator” had long been a staple of literature, since the time of the ancient Greek dramatist Aristophanes, but it had yet to be used in cinema. *Caligari* pioneers the use of this device in the character of Francis (Friedrich Fehér). The story Francis tells starts, innocently enough, with a love triangle, as two friends compete for the affections of the same woman—but of course, all is not as it seems.

The movie's screenwriters, Hans Janowitz and Carl Mayer, originally wrote the story as an indictment of Germany's government during World War I,

The somnambulist Cesare, who, the viewer is told, has been in a sleeping trance for 23 years, is roused by Caligari and fed sitting in his coffin.

with Caligari as a straightforward villain causing an innocent to sleepwalk into committing murder. As the movie neared production, however, the story morphed into something more complex, leading to possibly another first for cinema: the twist ending.

Opening the cabinet

Janowitz and Mayer were inspired by an 11th-century story about a confidence-trickster monk who exerted a strange influence over a man in his keep. In their screenplay, the monk became a doctor, whom Francis and his love rival Alan (Hans Heinrich von Twardowski) encounter at a village fairground.

Dr. Caligari (Werner Krauss) first appears as a fairground showman who opens his so-called cabinet—a coffin by any other name—to reveal the ghostly, heavy-lidded Cesare (Conrad Veidt) lying within.